RINGING IN THE NEW

From having 150,000 telephone exchange lines in 1947, India now is the world's second-largest telecommunications market with 1,200 million telephone subscribers

By ***M.G. Arun***



ON THE HORN The automatic telephone exhibit at the Indian Industries Fair in 1955

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Calcutta somehow has been intrinsic to India's telecom story. It was from the city to Diamond Harbour that the first experimental telegraph was started in 1850 in British India. Nearly a century and a half later, when mobile telephony landed on Indian shores, on July 31, 1995, it was to Jyoti Basu, the then chief minister of West Bengal, that Sukh Ram, the then Union telecom minister, made the first call, on Nokia cell phones.

When India gained Independence in 1947, the country had 150,000-odd telephone exchange lines, and state-run agencies under the posts and telegraph department manned the sector. The telephone remained a symbol of status rather than an object of utility for a long time, the number of connections growing from a mere 80,000 in 1948 to 980,000 in 1971, 2.15 million in 1981 and 5.07 million in 1991.

In 1981, Indira Gandhi, the then prime minister, signed contracts with French firm Alcatel CIT for a merger with Indian firm ITI,